countries. They have opened wide vistas for the development of our relations in the political, economic and cultural field.'

Despite working to a gruelling schedule, Honecker spent any free moments at his hunting lodge, where his daily routine varied little from previous years. Butler Lothar Herzog recalled his discipline was probably one of his greatest strengths:

When we would return from state visits, which were really all over the world, he would go to his office the following day – regardless of where the journey had taken us, or what the time difference had been. I admired that in him – because we felt the toll of all those trips we took, and yet we weren't under as much stress as he was.12

Back home, having assumed the problems of the winter weather response were squarely behind him, Honecker worked himself into a lather when reviewing recordings of Western TV news coverage. His jaw dropped as he watched hours of critical analysis of the poor East German response to the paralyzing storms, played in contrast to gushing reports about the FRG's faultless reaction in dealing with snow, ice and blizzards.

He fumed about ARD, the 'sabre-rattling' West German TV network, which seldom tiptoed around difficult topics. On one occasion, Honecker was incandescent when the channel made disparaging remarks on the costly purchase of new stretch Volvo limousines for high-ranking SED members (seven were bought for politburo members using hard currency). For years, he accused certain West German journalists accredited to the GDR of violating not only the spirit, but also the letter of the Helsinki agreement by 'not contributing to peace and the development of good relations'. In an interview with the Saarbrücker Zeitung, he bemoaned that critical reporting and slander were two different things and that 'GDR-FRG relations cannot be normalised when the truth is cancelled.'13 Though rarely agitated, he was equally frustrated at the 'chicanery' of dissidents criticising internal developments on FRG TV. He loathed critical 'man-in-the-street'